The Bell Witch

By Rachael Carnes

CHARACTERS: *JOHN BELL, a farmer; LUCY, his wife.*
SETTING: *Northern Robertson County, Tennessee. (1817)*
NOTE: *Imagine JOHN and LUCY'S children are here, too, witnessing.*

INTRODUCTION

ACTOR: *On the banks of the Red River in Robertson County lies the sleepy town of Adams, Tennessee.*
ACTRESS: *With a population of 624, you might think that the area would get overlooked. But for decades the town has captured the attention of ghost hunters and historians from all over the world.*
ACTOR: *Why? Because it is the site of the infamous haunting of the Bell Witch.*
ACTRESS: *According to legend, from 1817 to 1821 a man named John Bell and his family were harassed by this invisible spirit who had the ability to speak, shapeshift and be in multiple places at once.*
ACTOR: *Return with us to 1817 and experience this legend through*
TOGETHER: *The Bell Witch by Rachael Carnes*

Dim candlelight casts a pall on a wooden table, where LUCY dishes up thin stew for her husband JOHN, and their children.

JOHN: **(Pg 29-38)** The harvest being brought in, let us pray.

LUCY: John --

JOHN: Our father who art in heaven, we bless thee for this thy bounty.

LUCY: The children said they saw it again.

JOHN: For which we are about to receive --

LUCY: Out by the well --

JOHN: Now, my dear Lucy, this here's the richest farmland in the Red River Valley.

LUCY: Wolf with no head, John? In the woods --

JOHN: You'll scare the young uns. Let's to supper now.

LUCY: Cat with blazing eyes out by the shed. Goat on its hind legs --

JOHN: That's enough! How'd it look for a deacon in the church, his wife consortin' with --

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LUCY: We both been hearin' the knockin' sounds 'round the walls.

JOHN: Branches -- Wind. Don't worry, children --

LUCY: Last night I heard the knocks inside. Right by my bedside. Three still, loud knocks, like this.

JOHN: Your mother ain't felt right since we lost your baby brother.

LUCY: I been hearing it: Sounds like rats chewin' the bed post? Chains drug through the house.

JOHN: Let's all pray for poor little baby Benjamin, rocked in his cradle by the Lord Jesus in heaven.

LUCY: I'm cooking this supper and I hear what sounds like a stone dropped on the floor beside me --

JOHN: That vicious fever took a piece a' your momma with it --

LUCY: I look down at the floor and I don't see nothin' but wooden planks. Then I hear a chokin' sound.

JOHN: She'll be right as rain soon, just needs her rest.

LUCY: I'm standing and stirring the pot and I hear these walls gulping for air?

JOHN: It touches a mother's heart, to lose her child. Burns her, like a hot poker.

LUCY: John! This has gone on for a year now.

JOHN: No, it ain't! We enjoy a quiet, peaceful life.

LUCY: The children are terrified! Betsy saw some kinda creature --

JOHN: Betsy's been reading those storybooks again. I told you --

LUCY: And Drewry hears wings flapping against the ceiling over his bed. They all do --

JOHN: A sparrow, a bat gets in is all -- What'd you expect? This here's the country. Fresh air!

LUCY: John, we need help.

JOHN: Bring more shame on this family? No, thank you. I am an upstanding man.

LUCY: We could just ask the neighbors, if maybe they've --

JOHN: Your frailty as a wife and mother cripples this house, but I refuse to let you ruin my reputation.

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LUCY: You'd have our babies listen to the creaks and cracks -- The walls chokin'?

JOHN: Children: You must pray now to Jesus that your mother be delivered from this seditious fantasy.

LUCY: Joel's been struck. Richard William's had his hair pulled. Look at their bruises -- their cuts!

JOHN: Kids! They ***fight***.

LUCY: They was just standing there. Just today, I saw Jesse fly across the room, no hand laid upon him!

JOHN: If this "spirit" is so malicious, why you don't have a scratch on you?

LUCY: Because she --

JOHN: "She?"

LUCY: Yes, she. It be a woman, John. Wronged. Buried out there in those woods --

JOHN: Children, go to bed.

LUCY: ***She*** shakes 'em in the' sleep! Pulls their covers down -- puts icy fingers between their sheets!

JOHN: I don't want them to see their momma get a whoopin'.

LUCY: ***She*** hurts the children, but when I was sick with fever, she come to me. She tend me in my hour.

JOHN: John Junior, you go get a switch for me to use -- Rest of you, bed.

LUCY: I'm burnin' up, she cools my head with a wet cloth, she sings a little?

JOHN: I gotta drive the devil outta you.

LUCY: She says give her what she wants -- Or she'll stay here forever.

JOHN: And what does she want? Hmm? She want my sweat? My toil?

LUCY: She wants our land, John.

JOHN Well, she can't have it.

LUCY: And she wants her tooth back.

JOHN: Excuse me?

LUCY: I am a Spirit; I once was happy, but I have been disturbed and made unhappy.

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JOHN: What's wrong with you? Your voice is -- stop it right now!

LUCY: I am the Spirit of a person, buried in the woods nearby. My shallow grave's been disturbed --

JOHN: Ain't no grave out there.

LUCY: I'm disinterred and scattered.

JOHN: The dog's been bringing deer bones is all --

LUCY: One of my teeth -- this one -- is lost under the house. You seen it?

JOHN: Lucy Williams Bell! I will have no more of these incidents.

LUCY: I'm lookin' for my tooth.

JOHN: Now, Junior, that's a good boy, a fine piece a willow. Give it to your papa.

LUCY: And after I find my tooth, I'm gonna kill you.

JOHN: I got a switch in my hand now and so help me I will --

LUCY: But I'm not gonna do it quick.

JOHN: John Junior, you take your mama's arms. Hold for me -- She ain't well, son.

LUCY: I'm gonna keep pinching, scratching, poking you and yours with pins --

JOHN: Stop talking like that.

LUCY: How'd you get that nick on your chin, that abrasion, on your hand? Looks infected.

JOHN: Farm work -- Digging and plowing and -- Dirt gets in.

LUCY: You can't remember where those wounds come from, 'cuz it was me made you bleed.

JOHN: Your mind ain't right. Not since we left your people. I knew you couldn't do this.

LUCY: I'm gonna make it so you got a crowd gathered 'round your humble abode day and night.

JOHN: People warned me 'bout you. They said you was high hat -- City slicker. They was right!

LUCY: People will bring a picnic, wear they Sunday best, and steal a little dirt from outside, as a memento.

JOHN: No one's gonna hear about nothin. Your embarrassment stays within these walls.

LUCY: Suit yourself. I'll just set to swelling your throat. Make it dry and parched.

JOHN: I need some water --

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LUCY: At first, you will. Then after a while, it'll feel like you got a stick sideways in your throat.

JOHN: Junior, you may be inclined to look away. But there's sense in a man learning his obligations.

LUCY: You hit me, and I will weaken your muscles and break your bones, from the inside out.

JOHN: Ow -- I -- Can't, stand. I feel --

LUCY: Dizzy, John? Sit a spell. With no one around, Kate's got all the time in the world to poison you.

JOHN: Kate? Who's Kate?

LUCY: Buried out in the woods, all these years. My body left unattended.

JOHN: We're God-fearing folk. We're a good, decent family.

LUCY: But you're not a good man, John. Sign the deed to this farm -- Knowin' what happened here?

JOHN: Nothin' happened.

LUCY: Sign the papers in a backroom. Your loving wife waiting. Were you gonna tell her, about the --

JOHN: Nothing will happen! That's what the man said. It's all in the past!

LUCY: A woman died here, John. Walking by herself, collecting herbs. Men set upon her then slit her --

JOHN: All I did was buy the land! So I could start a family, and build the farm --

LUCY: Build the farm on the backs of your slaves.

JOHN: I heard them in their quarters, complaining about a wolf with no head -- So I beat 'em.

LUCY: The whip's your way, ain't it, John? Well, Kate's gonna see to that. Drop by drop.

JOHN: She can't. She ain't real. Lucy -- This is my last warning.

LUCY: A little pinch of arsenic in your water, a drip of cyanide in your stew. You won't see it or feel it.

JOHN: My darlin' Lucy --

LUCY: Until one day, your hair's fallin' out, your liver's rot.

JOHN: I don't want to hurt you.

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LUCY: I see you in the pulpit, on Sundays. Deliverin' your sermon: Starch white collar --

JOHN: The Lord is my shepherd --

LUCY: 'They'll come for me -- With their torches, their dogs.

JOHN: I shall not want.

LUCY: Funny thing, a mule.

JOHN: He leadeth me --

LUCY: Mistreat it, and they, say it looks for an opportunity to seek its revenge.

JOHN: He anointeth my soul --

LUCY: That mule remembers getting hit, punched. Remembers being scolded.

JOHN: Now I walk in the valley of good and evil --

LUCY: That mule looks for a moment when he can kick you in the head. Oops --

JOHN: My throat's -- I can't.

LUCY: Breathe?

JOHN: Stand --

LUCY: Bones, John? Like this one, under the table -- Or this one, next to chair?

JOHN: Those are just -- The stupid dog. Lucy! I love you.

LUCY: Name's not Lucy. It's Kate. Those men that set upon me used my body and didn't bury deep --

JOHN: That's in the eyes of God!

LUCY: When your wife told you I was talking to her, did you listen?

JOHN: She was tellin' tales. She ain't never been right.

LUCY: She's hangin' clothes or beatin' the carpet and she's hearin' voices and -- You know who it is.

JOHN: You shouldn't a been walking alone. It's your fault those men --

LUCY: Those men knocked my tooth loose. One of 'em put it in his pocket as a souvenir.

JOHN: I don't know nothing about your tooth.

LUCY: Wiped the blood on his boots and went home to his wife and children.

JOHN: I never seen it.

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LUCY: John, lying makes you ugly.

JOHN: I'm a good man. A respectable citizen.

LUCY: I been trying to warn you. Trying to get you to pay some attention. But you can't see. You know my missing tooth was all bundled up in the deed you signed. You bought the land from the man that murdered me. You know it was him, 'cuz you saw him do it. Stood there. Watched him have his way -- And slit my throat. Then y'all freeze like school girls. What now?

Dig a pitiful shallow empty, leave my body -- swear a pact. And when people go lookin for me? The finest men in the county haven't seen nothin. Except my molar, you keep here on the hearth.

JOHN: I'm a sinner.

LUCY: I'm gonna finish you off. But first, I'll make sure you're the laughing stock of the county.

JOHN: I'll repent!

LUCY: Too late.

JOHN: I'll get the neighbors -- I'll drive you away.

LUCY: You can try, but I'll wander restless tormenting you and your children until the day that you die. *(Beat)* More stew, John?

JOHN: Lucy -- Your voice.

LUCY: What is it, dear?

JOHN: You sound like yourself again. You feel okay now?

LUCY: Maybe.

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